EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Does God Change His Mind?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 3:8-10

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 3 (Commandment and Prohibition), the end of Chapter 8, Chapter 9 and the opening of Chapter 10

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 14 October 2024, on Zoom (the last shiur before Sukkot)

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where We Are in Essay 3

So far in the essay Saadia has explained:

- **Two categories of mitzvot**, the rational and the revelatory.
- **The prophets**: why we need them, and how they are verified, both to others and to themselves.
- **The three-part structure of Tanach**: command, consequence and narrative.
- **Chapter 7: can the Torah be abrogated?** Saadia's firm opinion is **no**. He brings sources he believes prove it, "but as we saw last time, it's not so straightforward": Rav Yosef Albo in **Sefer HaIkkarim** perhaps dissented, and other sources suggest things may be different in the time of Mashiach. He also refuted **seven arguments** for *bitul* (abrogation).
- **Chapter 8 began:** what if a prophet tries to take us away from the Torah **with miracles**? Miracles normally verify a prophet, but **even a miracle does not trump our intellect and logic**. "Even miracles have their limits."

Tonight: the rest of Chapter 8 (three verses), Chapter 9 (ten questions and two further points), and a start on Chapter 10.

Part 1: Chapter 8, Three Verses

Having dealt with logic, Saadia turns to **three verses** commonly brought in his time to prove the Torah was meant to change. "The third one is the most famous, which he spends the least time on."

1. "From Sinai, from Seir, from Paran"

"Timely," the Rabbi said: it comes from **Vezot HaBerachah**.

ה' מסיני בא וזרח משעיר למו הופיע מהר פארן

Hashem came from Sinai, shone forth to them from Seir, appeared from Mount Paran. (Devarim 33:2)

Saadia does not spell out the claim, but the Rabbi explained it: three revelations. **Sinai** is the Torah. **Seir** was read as **Jesus** and Christianity. **Paran** was read as **Muhammad**.

Saadia says no: **these are three names for the same place**.

- A mountain is called by **different names by the different towns around it**, just as a sea is called by different names in different countries. Mount Sinai is next to a place called Sinai, and **Seir and Paran are right next to it**.
- **Sinai and Paran adjoin:** the Israelites travelled from the wilderness of Sinai and the cloud rested in the wilderness of Paran.
- **Seir and Paran adjoin:** in Bereishit, the Chori in their hills of Seir, as far as El Paran.
- **Seir is Sinai:** in the Song of Devorah, "Hashem, when You went out from **Seir**..." and the next verse says "**this is Sinai**."

So the verse describes **one revelation, Matan Torah, from three angles**, called Sinai by us and Seir and Paran by other nations.

The remaining difficulty: Chavakuk.

אלוה מתימן יבוא וקדוש מהר פארן

God **will come** from Teiman, the Holy One from Mount Paran. (Chavakuk 3:3)

Chavakuk lived before Muhammad, so if Paran means Islam the future tense fits very well. But for Saadia, Paran is Sinai, already past. Why "**will** come"?

Saadia's answer is about Hebrew usage. **A constant action can be described in the past or the future.** In Tehillim, the sins in the desert are told in the past ("they rebelled at the Sea of Reeds," "they craved") and then, a few verses on, in the future ("the earth **will** open and swallow"). If someone does good to you constantly, you might say "he will do good to me." The Rabbi understood it so: **the revelation at Sinai continues to reverberate through the generations**, so the prophet speaks of it in the future.

The Rabbi added that **the Ibn Ezra** on this verse in Vezot HaBerachah quotes Saadia and says exactly the same.

2. "A messenger sent among the nations"

וציר בגוים שלח, קומו ונקומה עליה למלחמה

A messenger has been sent among the nations: rise up, let us rise against her in battle. (Ovadiah 1:1)

"Quite technical." The Christians read the messenger as **Jesus**, sent to wage war on paganism. Saadia says the messenger is **a prophet**, and the verse refers to the war in the days of **King Yehoshafat**, when the surrounding nations attacked. The king prayed, and Hashem sent the prophet **Yachaziel**, who told them to stand firm and watch Hashem's salvation. "Rise up for war" meant rise up **in prayer**: Yehoshafat appointed people to sing and praise Hashem, and they were saved from the enemy. "A very strong argument, and it's clear that's the intention of the pasuk."

3. "A new covenant"

הנה ימים באים נאם ה' וכרתי את בית ישראל ואת בית יהודה ברית חדשה, לא כברית אשר כרתי את אבותם... אשר המה הפרו את בריתי

Behold, days are coming, says Hashem, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Yehudah, not like the covenant I made with their fathers... which they broke. (Yirmiyahu 31)

"How ridiculous," says Saadia. **You bring me the verse, but you don't bother to look at the next one:** "**I will put My Torah within them**," this same Torah, and they will no longer teach each other bad things. And then: as surely as there is a sun, a moon and stars, **these laws will never cease**.

So what is new about the covenant? **Only that this time it will not be broken.** The earlier covenants were broken; Israel did not keep its side. The new covenant is new in the sense of **refreshed**: in the times of Mashiach Israel will keep its side of the pact as Hashem keeps His.

Part 2: Chapter 9, Ten Questions

"I want to try to finish both chapters tonight, so we can finish the essay and then take a break until after Sukkot."

Chapter 7 gave the logical arguments against abrogation; Chapter 8, the verses. Chapter 9 takes **questions people ask that seem to show Hashem changing His commands**, and if the Torah changed in the past, perhaps it will change again, perhaps there is a New Testament or a Quran. Saadia says there are many such questions. He will answer **ten**, and "look at the technique I'm answering": with it, you can answer all the others.

1. Adam's children married their sisters

"Really interesting. I had actually never thought of this until I read this." Adam and Chava had children. **Whom did those children marry**, to give Adam grandchildren? They must have married their sisters. Later Hashem forbade it. Abrogation?

Saadia: **marrying your sister was always forbidden**, even before the Torah. The proof is **Avraham**: going down to Avimelech, or to Pharaoh, he asks Sarah to say **"you are my sister"** so that they will not kill him. That only works if everyone knew **people did not marry their sisters**. Otherwise he should still fear for his life, since she might be his sister and his wife.

So how could Adam's children? **Because they had no choice.** There were no other humans. Once there were, the dispensation no longer applied:

- Someone ill **eats on Yom Kippur**. If he feels better halfway through the day, he cannot keep eating because he already broke his fast; the reason has gone, so he fasts again.
- Someone in the desert may eat **non-kosher food** when there is nothing else. The moment he has kosher food and is no longer starving, the excuse is gone.

"What I don't understand is who said this prohibition, and where. Who told humanity at the beginning you can't marry your sister? That's Saadia's understanding." And: "We read the story every year and I never paid attention to it."

2. Kayin was not executed

Kayin killed Hevel and was punished **with wandering**, yet later the Torah makes murder **a capital crime**. Saadia: there was no change. The death penalty applies only **with witnesses and a court** to try him. Kayin had neither, so Hashem gave him a different punishment.

"Surprising and interesting," the Rabbi said: according to Saadia, long before the Torah, the law was already that a murderer is put to death **given witnesses and a court**.

The Rabbi raised a difficulty from **the Gemara in Ketubot**: although the four capital punishments of the court have ceased, **the judgment of the four deaths has not ceased**. Hashem brings about the death of one who is liable, even without witnesses. So why did Hashem not tell Kayin his punishment was death? A participant suggested that perhaps Kayin did die early, since we do not know how he died. The Rabbi agreed we don't know, but "then why does Hashem not just say that to him?" What Hashem told him was **נע ונד תהיה בארץ**, you will be a wanderer in the land: a different punishment.

3. Who may offer sacrifices?

"This also I wasn't fully clear on." Before Vayikra, apparently anyone could offer sacrifices; afterwards, **only Aharon and his descendants**. Saadia: **it was never anyone at all.** Before Aharon too it had to be **an appointed person**, someone with that role. "Who appointed this person? Where do we find it in the Torah? I can't understand this."

Mark suggested from the class that **the firstborn** held that position, and it was transferred because of what they did. It was pointed out that the firstborn's role was transferred **to the Levi'im**, and the Torah counts the exchange. The Rabbi agreed it was a fair point: before, the appointed person may have been **the firstborn**, someone of importance; afterwards it is the Kohen. **It has always been someone appointed.**

4. Sacrifices on Shabbat

The Torah forbids work on Shabbat, yet sacrifices were offered on Shabbat. Saadia turns it on its head: **it proves the opposite.** Sacrifices were offered **before Shabbat was given**, so Hashem **did not abrogate them** and let them continue. The same with **brit milah** on the eighth day, commanded long before the Torah, and still done on Shabbat. The Torah prohibited things that were never commanded before; what was already commanded continues.

5. The Akeidah

Hashem told Avraham to offer Yitzchak, then told him not to harm him. Saadia: "a completely incorrect question. **Even people who believe in abrogation** can't use it." Abrogation means a law is given, **fulfilled**, then replaced; here **nothing was fulfilled**. Rather, Hashem revealed at the end what He meant from the start: **"bring him up."** That's it. Once Avraham brought him up and prepared the knife and the wood, he had done what he was told. "That was always the intention of Hashem."

6. Bilam: "don't go" and then "go"

Rashi asks this on the Torah. Hashem told Bilam not to go with Balak's messengers, then a few verses later told him to go.

	Answer
Rashi	Hashem advised him not to go, but seeing how much he wanted to, said: if you really want to, go. As with **the spies**: "my advice is not to go; if you want to, you can." Not a change
Saadia	**Two different groups.** "Don't go" meant **not with this group**. Balak then sent **more honourable** messengers, and Hashem said go **with these**, so that it would be reported that Israel was saved even from someone as important as Balak, who sent his whole cabinet to fetch Bilam, and still could not defeat them

7. Chizkiyahu

Hashem told Chizkiyahu he would die, and then gave him **fifteen more years**. Saadia: that is how Hashem works. He warns and decrees, and **if you do teshuvah**, the decree is revoked. The Rabbi linked it to the Rambam's rule from a few weeks earlier: a prophet's failed prediction of **bad** is not yet proof he is false, because the people may have repented, as with **Yonah**, read on Yom Kippur the week before, whose warning to Nineveh was annulled when they did teshuvah.

8. The Levi'im replace the firstborn

"Mark, this touches what you said." Saadia: **a king promotes his subjects**, and if they do not do their job well, they are demoted. Hashem gave Adam paradise and then expelled him; He brought us to the Land and then exiled us. So too the firstborn had the privilege and lost it.

9. Yericho on Shabbat

"This is very interesting." The Israelites circled Yericho for seven days, and people assumed **the seventh day, when the walls fell, was Shabbat**: war on Shabbat. Saadia says that is **a wrong assumption**. One of the seven days was Shabbat, and on it they **circled the city and blew the shofar** (biblically there is nothing wrong with blowing shofar, and apparently carrying the Ark was allowed). But **the destruction on the seventh day happened on a weekday**. Nowhere does it say the seventh day was Shabbat.

"The problem is, either he didn't have this Yerushalmi in front of him..." **The Yerushalmi** says explicitly that a commanded war may be fought even on Shabbat, **because Yericho was conquered on Shabbat**. That is what all the Rishonim say and how the halacha is decided: ***milchemet chovah***, an obligatory war, may be waged on Shabbat. Saadia either did not know it, or was bothered by the question of abrogation, and he answered differently.

10. The direction of prayer

First we prayed towards **the Mishkan**, then towards **the Temple**. Hashem changed His mind? No. We were always commanded to pray **towards the Ark**. The Ark was in different places, so we faced different directions, but **the point never changed**.

#	Question	Saadia's answer
1	Adam's children married their sisters	No choice; always forbidden
2	Kayin not executed	No witnesses or court
3	Sacrifices: anyone, then only Aharon	Always an appointed person
4	Sacrifices on Shabbat	Commanded before Shabbat, so continued (like milah)
5	The Akeidah	"Bring him up", and he did
6	Bilam	Not this group; the next one
7	Chizkiyahu's fifteen years	Teshuvah revokes a decree
8	Levi'im for the firstborn	Promotion and demotion
9	Yericho on Shabbat	The conquest was on a weekday
10	Direction of prayer	Always towards the Ark

Part 3: What Does *Olam* Mean?

In Chapter 7 Saadia used ***olam*** to prove eternity: **חקת עולם**, an everlasting statute. People object that *olam* can mean three things: **fifty years**; **the lifespan of the generation addressed**; or **everlasting**. Saadia replies that **Yirmiyahu**, about 850 years after Moshe, still commanded keeping Shabbat. That is long after fifty years and long after Moshe's generation, so *olam* there means **everlasting**.

"I have no clue what he's talking about here. I tried to discover what he meant, but I don't understand." The question was about the **Hebrew servant**, whose ear is pierced and who serves **le'olam**, which the Hachamim read as until the Yovel. Shabbat proves Shabbat; how does that answer the servant? The Rabbi's best explanation: although *olam* alone can mean fifty years, the phrase **chukat olam**, an everlasting **law**, is used of Shabbat, and there it plainly means forever. So **every *chukat olam* means forever**. "That's the only way I have to explain it."

"Perhaps you misunderstood the tradition"

How can you be sure the tradition meant eternity? This, the Rabbi reminded the class, is **the skeptic** of Essay 1, one of the thirteen views Saadia argued against. Saadia's reply: **is there anything in the world certain to you?** If he says no, he is simply a skeptic, and "I don't talk to such people." If he says yes, then we answer that we know with certainty the law was given, and the tradition, the *kabbalah* with which Saadia opened Chapter 7, is that it is for eternity.

Part 4: The Brahmins and Adam

The last part of the chapter concerns **the Brahmins**, a Hindu sect from around 500 BCE, long before Saadia. People argued from them: **Adam permitted** wearing ***shatnez***, ploughing with

an ox and a donkey together, and (in the Rabbi's edition) **meat and milk**. If laws never change, why did the Torah forbid them?

"I don't understand these people," says Saadia. **The Brahmins don't even say this.** They say Adam **allowed** these things, and we agree: before the Torah, they were optional. Forbidding what was optional is not abrogation. And if a Brahmin now claimed that Adam **commanded** them to do these things, "that's nonsense." That was never their tradition: **why did you not say so yesterday?**

Saadia's closing inspiration

Saadia ends the chapter with a challenge. I have worked so hard, gone through all the verses, all the logic and all the questions, to prove to you that **the Torah will not be abrogated**. Will you not now put in the effort **to keep it**? Will all my effort be in vain?

Chapters 7-9 in brief: Chapter 7, the tradition, some verses and logical reasons. Chapter 8, the verses from Tanach that seem to prove abrogation. Chapter 9, the ten questions, *chukat olam*, and the Brahmins. Saadia's conclusion: **there is no proof that the Torah can be abrogated.**

Part 5: Chapter 10, Twelve Questions from Chivi al-Balkhi

Chapter 10 is **not about abrogation**. Since the essay is about the Torah and its commandments, Saadia goes through **twelve general questions** that trouble people so much they say they cannot believe in the Torah. "Some of them are quite strong ones."

Who was Chivi al-Balkhi?

These twelve are part of **200 questions** raised by **Chivi al-Balkhi**, **a biblical critic**. It is not clear whether he was a Jew or a Christian. He offered 200 objections to the divine origin of the Bible, and Saadia was very upset that people were learning his books. Saadia wrote a book of responses, as we learned in his Introduction, but it is lost. Here he chose twelve, presumably **the strongest**, "and he's saying, if I don't deal with them, people will be confused and may come to heresy." "He's very confident, as we see over and over, that his explanations are the right ones."

Saadia first summarises what he has done: abrogation; why prophets live like other humans, so as to show the prophet is a normal person; and in the earlier essays **the Creator**, against **anthropomorphism**, and the attributes we use of Hashem. "If I didn't do this, people would become heretics." Before Essay 4, twelve more things must be cleared up.

Question 1: the Torah is unclear

What is the point of a book in which so many mitzvot have **no explanation**? Why adhere to an incomplete, unclear book?

Saadia: **the Five Books are not the only source of our law.** There are two other springs:

Spring	When
The spring of intellect	Before the Torah
The Torah itself	
The spring of tradition	After the Torah was given

Whatever is unclear in the Torah, intellect and tradition together complete it, **in quality and in quantity**.

Question 2: contradictions in the numbers

Saadia, the Rabbi said, is **one of the first to discuss** this kind of biblical criticism; critics would later claim two different editions were put together. In **Shmuel**, Yoav's census counts **800,000** men of war in Israel. In **Divrei HaYamim** it counts **1,100,000**. A discrepancy of **300,000**.

(Mark helped with the arithmetic in the shiur: *elef alafim u'me'ah elef* is **a million and a hundred thousand**.)

Saadia's answer, "straight out from Chazal":

- **800,000** is the standing **army**.
- **300,000** are **reservists**.
- A verse elsewhere says **24,000 served each month**: 24,000 x 12 = **288,000**.
- The remaining **12,000** came from **the princes**, the *nesi'im*, and their families.
- 288,000 + 12,000 = 300,000. "Actually fits in beautifully."

The Rabbi connected this to the rule we say every morning in Shacharit among Rabbi Yishmael's **thirteen principles**, and found in **the 32 principles of Rabbi Eliezer son of Rabbi Yose HaGelili**: when **two verses contradict each other, a third verse comes and reconciles them**. The proof brought for it is **these very verses**, with the verse of the 24,000 as the third.

"The third one is a really strong one, and actually I spent quite some time looking into this. But that we will have to leave for next time."

Summary

1. **Three verses (Chapter 8):** Sinai, Seir and Paran are **one mountain** with three names (Chavakuk's future tense describes a revelation that keeps reverberating); the **messenger among the nations** is the prophet Yachaziel in Yehoshafat's day; the **new covenant** is the same Torah, written within them, that this time will not be broken.
2. **Ten questions (Chapter 9):** each apparent change is no change: dispensation (Adam's children), missing witnesses (Kayin), an appointed person (sacrifices), prior commands continuing (sacrifices and milah on Shabbat), a command fulfilled ("bring him up"), different messengers (Bilam), teshuvah (Chizkiyahu), promotion and demotion (the Levi'im), a weekday conquest (Yericho, against the Yerushalmi), and one constant direction (the Ark).

3. ***Chukat olam*** means forever, as with Shabbat 850 years after Moshe; the skeptic who doubts the tradition doubts everything.
4. **The Brahmins** only say Adam **permitted** these things, which is no abrogation. Saadia's appeal: after all my effort to prove it, **put in the effort to keep it**.
5. **Chapter 10** begins Chivi al-Balkhi's questions: the Torah is completed by **intellect and tradition**, and the census numbers reconcile through **reservists serving monthly**.

Coming Up

- **A break for Sukkot.** The shiur resumes after Sukkot, **most likely on the Monday after Shabbat Bereishit**, to finish Essay 3 with the rest of Chapter 10.
- **Then Essay 4**, on our worship of Hashem: Essay 3 was the more philosophical side of the mitzvot; Essay 4 is more about **how to serve Hashem**.
- The Rabbi wished everyone **Chag Sameach**.

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